

The Wasserstein Distance

For a metric space $(\mathcal{X}, d)$, take $c(x, y) = d(x, y)^p, p \geq 1$. This yields the the **Wasserstein Distance**:

$$W_p(\alpha, \beta) = \left(\inf_{\pi \in \Pi(\alpha, \beta)} \int_X d(x, y)^p \, d\pi(x, y) \right)^{1/p}$$

Leonid Wasserstein (Васерштейн)



- Also written: Vaseršteĭn, Vasershtein
- Soviet mathematician born in Kharkiv
- Specialized in algebra, K-theory, group theory
- Longtime professor at Penn State
- 1969: introduced the metric on probability distributions that now bears his name, as a tool for functional analysis
- Legacy: Wasserstein metric became a cornerstone concept linking probability, analysis, and geometry.

